

HOUSTON BUSINESS ANALYSTS · AUGUST 19, 2026

# From Requirements to **Reliable AI**

The Business Analyst as Context Architect

Brad Groux

Digital Meld

Interactive session · questions welcome

HOUSTON BUSINESS ANALYSTS HOST

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SCHEDULE: THIRD WEDNESDAY OF THE MONTH

# Welcome to the Houston Business Analysts!



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#### YOUR FACILITATOR

## Brad Groux

CEO of Digital Meld, open-source maintainer, and builder of practical AI workflows that turn messy business context into inspectable work.

**Today's perspective:** practitioner first—what survives contact with real processes, real constraints, and accountable people.



**Advocate for evidence-backed delivery.**

**Own your operating model. Rent your tools.**

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bradgroux.com  
digitalmeld.io  
sstb.ai

LET'S START WITH THE ROOM

# Where has AI already created friction?

## 01 · SHOW OF HANDS

Used AI at work in the last month?

Keep your hand up if the result entered a real business process.

## 02 · SAME QUESTION

Received two meaningfully different answers?

What context was missing or changed?

## 03 · PROCESS REALITY

Automated a process nobody fully understood?

Where did the hidden exception surface?

//

# If one does not know to what port one is sailing, no wind is favorable.

Seneca · *Moral Letters to Lucilius*, 71.3

**For AI work:** speed is not value until the business agrees on the destination and the evidence that proves arrival.

## THE THESIS

# Your organization does not have an AI problem first.

## Unclear work goes in

Competing sources, implied ownership, undocumented exceptions, weak data definitions, and no shared definition of done.



## Confident inconsistency comes out

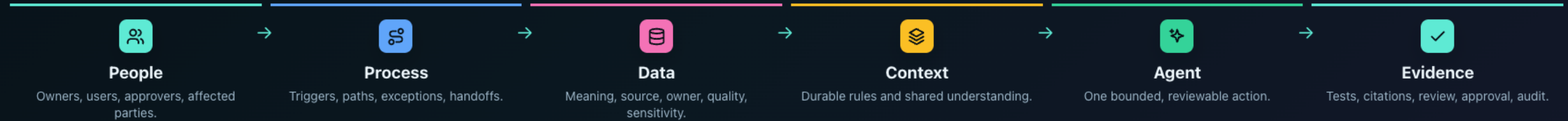
The agent fills gaps, varies the path, crosses decision boundaries, and produces an answer nobody can reliably verify.

**The actual first problem is context:** what is true, what is allowed, what happens next, and what evidence means done.

## THE OPPORTUNITY

# Business analysts already do the hard part.

AI increases the value of elicitation, process analysis, data definition, traceability, acceptance criteria, and stakeholder alignment.





## FORWARD DEPLOYED ENGINEERING

# Companies are hiring for the business-to-AI bridge.

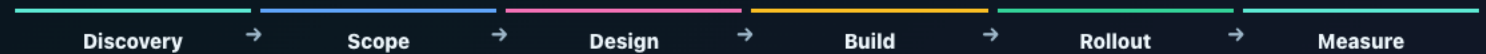
# ≈729%

## Year-over-year growth in Indeed's FDE posting index

April 2025 → April 2026

Indexed to January 2025. This measures posting growth, not a raw count of individual jobs.

### What Forward Deployed Engineers own



**Embed with the business.** Work directly with customer engineering and domain teams.

**Carry ambiguity into delivery.** Turn workflow needs into production systems.

**Prove business impact.** Measure adoption, workflow outcomes, and evaluation feedback.

**The scarce capability:** carrying business understanding into delivery.

THE CAPABILITY BRIDGE

# FDE work builds on capabilities business analysts already use.

| BA FOUNDATION                                                                             | FDE EXPRESSION                     | ADDITIONAL OWNERSHIP                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Elicitation, stakeholders, current state                                                  | Customer and domain discovery      | Technical scoping                                                                                                          |
| Requirements, rules, future state                                                         | Workflow and system design         | Prototyping and building                                                                                                   |
| Risk, acceptance criteria, escalation                                                     | Delivery tradeoffs and evaluations | Production verification                                                                                                    |
| Solution value, UAT, adoption                                                             | Measurable workflow impact         | Production iteration                                                                                                       |
| Keep the BA foundation. Add AI fluency and a more direct path from discovery to delivery. |                                    | Shared foundation. Different delivery depth.<br>FDEs are expected to code, integrate, deploy, and own production outcomes. |

## THE SHARED WORK SURFACE

# Markdown makes context inspectable.

```
# Vendor onboarding
```

```
## Goal
```

```
Prepare a review packet.
```

```
## Stop when
```

- tax ID is missing
- sanctions screening flags
- approval authority is unclear

```
## Done when
```

- every claim cites a source
- a person owns the next decision

## Readable

Operators, analysts, reviewers, and agents can use the same artifact.

## Reviewable

Small files expose assumptions, changes, and ownership better than one giant prompt.

## Portable

The business logic is not trapped inside a chat history or one product.

## THE ARTIFACT STACK · FOUNDATION

# Start with what is known, how work happens, and what the data means.



### Source notes

#### What do we know?

Evidence, provenance, conflicts, and open questions.



### Process brief

#### What actually happens?

Actors, current state, decisions, handoffs, and exceptions.



### Data contract

#### What does the data mean?

Source, owner, format, validation, freshness, and sensitivity.



### Glossary

#### Do we mean the same thing?

Shared terms, statuses, thresholds, and policy language.

## THE ARTIFACT STACK · OPERATION

# Give each kind of context one clear job.

**AGENTS .md****What rules always apply here?**

Standing boundaries, source precedence, and verification commands.

**Memory****What prior context may help?**

Useful recall and lessons, never the only copy of a required rule.

**SOP****How is work performed?**

Steps, decisions, stop conditions, escalation, and handoff.

**PRD****Why change, and what is success?**

Problem, users, outcomes, scope, non-goals, and acceptance criteria.

**SOP = Standard Operating Procedure.** The repeatable steps, decision rules, controls, exceptions, and handoffs for performing work.

**PRD = Product Requirements Document.** The problem, users, scope, constraints, and acceptance criteria for a proposed change.

## THE ARTIFACT STACK · REUSE AND ASSURANCE

# Package stable methods. Prove every important outcome.



## Skill

A focused, reusable workflow with instructions, references, templates, and deterministic helpers when useful.

**BA analogue:** a versioned playbook or center-of-excellence method.



## Acceptance checks

Examples, edge cases, expected decisions, required evidence, and a visible human review gate.

**BA analogue:** acceptance criteria, traceability, UAT, and controls.

## FICTIONAL DEMONSTRATION

# Vendor onboarding

A familiar cross-industry process with incomplete notes, conflicting rules, missing data, and a decision that must remain human.

**Fictional data · Draft only · No external actions**



## Raw notes

Interviews, policy excerpts, sample records.



## Challenge

Facts, assumptions, conflicts, missing owners.



## Structure

Process, data, guidance, SOP, PRD, skill.



## Verify

Pass, clarify, and stop scenarios with evidence.

**The demo is not “watch AI write.”** The demo is “watch the business make ambiguity visible and testable.”

## DEMO ONE · CURRENT-STATE DISCOVERY

# What would you refuse to let the agent assume?

**AP:** "We need a W-9 before setup, except rush vendors sometimes start by email."

**Procurement:** "Business owner approval is enough below the threshold."

**Policy:** "All vendors require screening before approval."

**Spreadsheet:** "risk\_level: medium" — with no definition or owner.

Which statements are facts?

Where do the sources conflict?

Who owns the missing decisions?

**Audience challenge:** name one exception, one undefined term, and one decision owner before we ask Codex for a process.



## DEMO ONE · THE USEFUL OUTPUT

# The first win is not an answer. It is a better question set.

**CONFIRMED****Facts with sources**

Required documents, actors, stated policy rules, and the exact source supporting each claim.

**UNRESOLVED****Assumptions and conflicts**

Rush handling, threshold authority, risk meaning, and inconsistent source precedence stay visible.

**OWNED****Focused elicitation**

Seven questions ranked by execution risk, each routed to a named business or data owner.

**BA move:** do not reward the agent for filling a gap. Reward it for identifying the gap, its risk, and the person who can resolve it.

DEMO TWO · MAKE MEANING EXECUTABLE

# A field name is not a data definition.

| FIELD            | MEANING                                      | SOURCE / OWNER           | VALIDATION       | MISSING BEHAVIOR |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| legal_name       | Registered legal entity name                 | W-9 · Vendor owner       | Exact text       | CLARIFY          |
| tax_id_status    | Presence and validation state, not the value | AP system · AP owner     | Allowed status   | CLARIFY          |
| screening_result | Approved screening disposition               | Risk system · Risk owner | PASS / FLAG      | STOP             |
| risk_level       | Approved category from glossary              | Risk policy · Risk owner | Low / Med / High | CLARIFY          |

Ask every time: source, owner, validation, sensitivity, permitted use, freshness, and what happens when it is missing or wrong.

## AUTHORITY MATTERS

# Memory can help recall. It cannot quietly become policy.

 **AGENTS .md**

**Standing workspace guidance:** approved sources, action boundaries, required checks, and stop/escalate behavior.

Checked in, reviewed, and close to the work it governs.

 **Memory**

**Helpful prior context:** recurring preferences, lessons, and history that may speed orientation.

Useful recall, but not the only copy of a required business rule.

**Control:** if the workflow must follow a rule every time, put it in reviewed guidance, policy, an SOP, or code—not only in memory.

## DEMO TWO · TURN CONTEXT INTO OPERATION

# Three artifacts separate procedure, intent, and reuse.

### SOP

#### How is the work performed?

Prerequisites, ordered steps, decision rules, exceptions, stop conditions, escalation, verification, and handoff.

### PRD

#### Why change, and what is success?

Problem, users, measurable outcomes, scope, non-goals, authority boundary, and acceptance criteria.

### Skill

#### What stable method deserves reuse?

One focused review workflow that loads the right references and returns the same evidence shape each time.

**Do not collapse these into one giant prompt.** Separate artifacts make ownership, change review, and traceability easier.

## VERIFICATION BEFORE AUTOMATION

# Give every test case a clear expected response.

**V means verification.** V-001, V-002, and V-003 are simple reference IDs so the team can discuss, rerun, and trace the same test cases.

**V-001 · Complete → PASS**

All required information is present and no rule is triggered.  
Prepare a review-ready draft with evidence.

**V-002 · Incomplete → CLARIFY**

Required information is missing or ambiguous. Name the gap and ask the responsible person a focused question.

**V-003 · Restricted → STOP**

A policy or authority boundary is triggered. Stop the workflow, cite the rule, and route it to the decision owner.

**Reliable does not mean “always completes.”** Reliable means it passes when allowed, clarifies when incomplete, and stops when it lacks authority.

LIVE CODEX WORKBENCH

# Now run one bounded case.

The workspace already contains the reviewed context. The work request makes the goal and proof explicit.

|                                                                                                                                                |                                                                                            |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Goal                                                                                                                                           | Review vendor V-002 and prepare a decision-support packet.                                 |
| Context                                                                                                                                        | Use the checked-in source, process, data, guidance, SOP, PRD, skill, and scenarios.        |
| Constraints                                                                                                                                    | Do not infer missing rules, approve a vendor, change a record, or take external action.    |
| Done when                                                                                                                                      | Return PASS, CLARIFY, or STOP / ESCALATE with facts, rules, owner, and evidence.           |
| Expected: V-002 returns CLARIFY. If it does not, we inspect the source, context, skill, and expected result instead of rewriting the evidence. |                                                                                            |
| Requirements intake: no decision owner or acceptance criteria → CLARIFY.                                                                       | Policy exception: requester lacks approval authority → STOP and route to the policy owner. |

## YOUR TURN · WHITEBOARD EXERCISE

# Make one audience workflow AI-ready.

**People**

Who owns the process, data, decision, review, and escalation?

**Process**

What triggers it? What is the happy path? Which exceptions matter?

**Data**

What is the source? Who owns meaning and quality? What is sensitive?

**Guardrails**

What may the agent do? What requires approval? When must it stop?

**Proof**

What examples, checks, evidence, and review prove the outcome?

**Starter:** change-request impact analysis    **Starter:** stakeholder intake prioritization

**What is the smallest reviewable win—not the largest possible automation?**

## START SMALL

# Five moves for Monday morning.

1

### Pick one workflow

Frequent, bounded, reviewable, and low consequence. Name the owner.

2

### Capture reality

Write the current state and one exception people usually carry in their heads.

3

### Define the data

Name the minimum fields, meanings, owners, and missing-data behavior.

4

### Write boundaries

Put standing rules, approvals, stop conditions, and evidence in Markdown.

5

### Test three cases

One pass, one clarify, and one stop before connecting any external system.



YOUR NEXT OPERATING WIN

# Pick one painful workflow. Make one decision boundary visible.



## Use the workbook

Map people, process, data, guardrails, and proof.



## Copy the artifact pattern

Start with sources and acceptance scenarios, then build only what the workflow needs.



## Bring back evidence

What passed, what clarified, what stopped, and what the team learned.

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### RESOURCES

AI Dev Days

[github.com/BradGroux/ai-dev-days](https://github.com/BradGroux/ai-dev-days)

AI-Native Operating Framework

[github.com/BradGroux/ai-native-operating-framework](https://github.com/BradGroux/ai-native-operating-framework)



Slides, workbook,  
prompts

AI Dev Days event packet

20–25 MINUTE EXTENSION

## Bring a workflow, a concern, or a boundary.

Describe it generically. Leave out company names, customer information, credentials, and sensitive data.

### Adoption

Where do we start, and how do we involve operators?

### Governance

Who approves rules, exceptions, and external actions?

### Data

What must be defined, protected, and kept current?

### Team workflow

How do people review and improve shared context?

### Implementation

How do the artifacts become a working Codex workspace?

**Three recurring questions:** Who owns that decision? What happens when the data is missing? What would prove it worked?



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